



The Tech-sense

All of the people working in research labs, all those working in hardware and software companies, all of us working at Digit, and all of you – readers of tech magazines, web sites, and tech enthusiasts – all taken together, constitute a minority in the grand scheme of things. And not the whole of that minority, mind you, knows enough about technology to practise it well.

Over the past decade or so, I have seen technology enter every aspect of our lives, and the mobile phone is perhaps now the starting point for most of the world. However, I still find so many causes for complaint, when I encounter people who should just know better.

I can't begin to describe the disappointment I feel when I speak to customer service representatives who know less than I do about their product. And no, I'm not special, most of you who read this magazine, have had similar encounters.

Almost every month I find myself arguing, quite fruitlessly, with my ISP's representatives, over some issue or another. Most often it's a badly configured server, or some technical problem with their lines that causes me to call them. Of course all I get in return is standard verbiage, and ridiculous requests to "delete my IE cache". I don't even use IE, and what's IE got to do with the fact that their DNS server is down? Why should I have to spend 15 minutes of my life, every month, educating people about how their system is supposed to work?

The common everyday system assembler is no different. I can't tell you how many times I've seen rear system fans pushing air into a cabinet, instead of out; or CPUs that run hot because the guy who threw it together thought, "Thermal paste? You can probably never have enough!"

The technology service providers across SoHos and SMBs are no better. Yes I will admit that there are quite a few gems, in this field, but overall, it's just sad to see the pathetic state of knowledge and awareness.

I've spoken to quite a few small business owners who just cannot seem to find an affordable and reliable enough maintenance provider. One such company's network was recently assailed by the Conficker worm, and a whole host of other malware. As usual, the sys-admin (from an outsourced company), felt the best solution was to format-reinstall Windows on individual computers. However, it was sad to see that he didn't seem to have the common sense to unplug the LAN cable when reinstalling the OS, ensuring to plug it back in only after installing an updated anti-virus software. As a result, by the time I pointed this out to him, he had formatted and reinstalled Windows on 3 PCs

over 4 times each! Shouldn't someone you pay to protect your PCs and data know such a basic thing? What about all the man-hours wasted?

Working in a media company, I also get a lot of FTP login details, to get ads, transfer pages, download images – the usual deal. I can't begin to tell you how many times I've found the passwords to be weak, and sometimes, it's the same as the root password to the actual server's OS!

Then there's the whole web site business, which is just another example of the visually impaired leading the blind. I've seen people with a distrust for open source software's security, get custom-coded solutions that either break or have security holes the size of a bus. Very often, the "product" provided is just an open source package that's coded on top of, without proper understanding of, the original code, thus resulting in security holes. If not, then it's custom-coded, without following some basic principles of security.

The advantage we've always had at Digit, is the fact that we're all a bunch of technology fanatics. There's always someone around who will offer up better solutions, and all of us can troubleshoot, rip apart and rebuild our own PCs. We're blessed with a lot of people who have the "tech sense" – or basically a combination of common sense, technology knowledge and experience.

Although this tech sense has helped us stay numero uno in your eyes, we're not content to sit back and do nothing more. Doing more, however, is not possible if we look at you as "readers" of a magazine. Starting this month, and hopefully a regular feature from now on – depending on the way you respond – we will be looking to interact more with you. Whether it's online through our web site, via e-mail, in real-time via live chats, or face-to-face workshops, we're going to go beyond the scope of any "magazine", and try to empower the tech community of India.

Whether it's saving you assembly costs by teaching you how to do it yourself, or helping you use technology better, we're going to listen to some of our readers who asked for an increased level of interaction, and help more people develop better "tech sense".

Turn to page 28 to find out more, and don't forget to write in and tell me if you have some suggestions about how we can help more.

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